

YORK RITE BODIES OF HIGHER LEARNING IN ANCIENT CRAFT MASONRY

Capitular and Cryptic Degrees

Mark Master
Past Master (virtual)
Royal Master
Select Master
Most Excellent Master
Royal Arch Mason



Chivalric Orders

Order of Red Cross
Order of Knights of Malta
Order of Knights
Templar

To The Brother Seeking further knowledge of Light and Truth:

Please complete a petition for the Bodies offering you the additional Degrees and Orders that will enable you to complete your Masonic education commenced when you received the first three Degrees in Masonry. These Degrees and Orders are not designated by numbers, but are known by significant, symbolic names. A brief outline of the several Degrees and Orders offered by the Bodies that, in addition to the Blue Lodge with its basic symbolic Degrees, comprise what is commonly referred to as York Rite Masonry.

Together, these Bodies form an aggregate whole that provides the only complete understanding of Ancient Craft Masonry. You learned early in your Masonic career that Masonry was a progressive science denoting advancement. Therefore, it is only fitting and proper that you should take advantage of every opportunity for self-improvement and never be satisfied to remain in a static condition.

Basic and indispensable as they are to the foundation of all Masonry, the Entered Apprentice, Fellowcraft, and Master Mason Degrees of the Blue Lodge comprise the beginning, not the ultimate in Masonic knowledge - just as reading, writing and arithmetic are stepping stones for all higher learning. The Virginia York Rite Bodies of "advanced learning" are the Chapter of Royal Arch Masons and the Commandery of Knights Templar where a harmonious relationship exists between them. The several Degrees and Orders of these Bodies complete the beautiful story of Freemasonry begun in the Blue Lodge.

You will never regret your decision to complete your "Masonic Education." The two petitions contained herein are your "keys" to further learning. Any member of the York Rite Bodies will be happy to sponsor your application. The fees are nominal. The dues are small and the advantages of membership are many.

CHAPTER OF ROYAL ARCH MASONS (Capitular and Cryptic Degrees)



Mark Master Degree is one of the most important Degrees of the entire York Rite system and is considered one of the most instructive in all Freemasonry. Amplifying the Fellowcraft Degree and containing lessons of value in all walks of life, it portrays the encouraging truth that though we are often misunderstood, under-rated and traduced, there is ONE who will make the rejected stone the Head of the Corner. It explains the manner in which the ancient operative craftsmen were known and distinguished in receiving their wages and derives its name from the Order of Mark Master or an advanced class of Fellowcrafts who each possessed an individual "mark" which they used to designate their own work.



Past Master's Degree, once a part of the Symbolic Degrees of the Blue Lodge and originally conferred only on those who had served as Masters of a Masonic Lodge, is truly a sublime ritual of mental and spiritual "preparation" for the earnest seeker of further Light in Masonry. Those receiving the Degree are designated as "virtual" Past Masters, as distinguished from "actual" Past Masters. Here, as

an indispensable prerequisite to exaltation in the Royal Arch Degree, the candidate is taught that he must first learn to obey before he can rule, and to govern himself before he can govern others.



Royal Master Degree takes you back in time to the day before the death of the builder, who once again is the central character as he was in the Third Degree. Fully explaining many of the symbols of Freemasonry. It is preparatory to and intimately connected with the Degree of Select Master and contains much information necessary to the correct understanding of preceding Degrees as well as valuable instruction on the preservation of our Masonic traditions.



Select Master Degree, historically, predates the Third Degree and deals with incidents which occurred at the building of the first Temple. A highly dramatic and interesting Degree of Ancient Craft Masonry. It is closely related to and elaborates on the teachings in the Royal Arch Degree.

Most Excellent Master Degree is based on the completion and dedication of King Solomon's Temple, from which the idea of all Masonic symbolism originated, this is a significant and spectacular Degree. Here, the Temple, begun so auspiciously and halted so dramatically in the Third Degree, is finally completed.



Royal Arch Degree, the climax of Ancient Craft Masonry and Masonic symbolism, this Degree is a story of Jewish history during some of its darkest hours. Based on the subject of love of Home and Country, its lessons are those of Service and Fortitude. It teaches the ultimate triumph of Truth over all forms of superstition and error, proper respect for the Deity and His works, and the worship of the one true God, under whatsoever name He may be worshipped. Here the TRUE WORD, and all that it symbolically signified, is revealed. Therefore, this Degree is really indispensable to every earnest seeker of Masonic Light and he who attains it is truly "Exalted".

COMMANDERY OF KNIGHTS TEMPLAR (Chivalric Orders)

Only qualified Masons who believe in the divinity of Jesus Christ may petition a Commandery for membership. The "circle of perfection" in Ancient Craft Masonry was completed in the Council of Cryptic Masons. But it is in the Commandery that the impressive lessons and beautiful ceremonies of the preceding degrees are dramatically and directly applied to the Christian way of life.



Order of Red Cross It is here that the first direct connection is established between the preceding Degrees and the Chivalric Orders. The emblem of the Order is the Red Cross, and each of its four arms has important symbolic allusions.



Order of Malta Strictly Christian in origin and character, this Order receives its name from the Island of Malta and its setting dates back to the time of the Crusades when admission to the Order was sought as a means of safe pilgrimage to the Holy Sepulcher. The Maltese Cross is the emblem of the Order.



Order of the Temple This Order is solemn, impressive and soul-searching. It receives its name from the original Crusaders, the first Christian protectors of Jerusalem sworn to protect the Pilgrims to the Holy Land and uphold the Cross. This ritual still retains some of the ceremonies of the original Order. Founded on the New Testament, this Order is the fitting climax to the labors of the humble penitent, culminating in his Knighting as a Christian Warrior. The emblem of a Knight Templar is the Passion Cross, ever a symbol of sacrifice, and a reminder of the spirit of refined and moral chivalry which prompts members of the Order to be ever ready to defend the weak, the innocent the helpless and the depressed - in the true spirit of Christ.